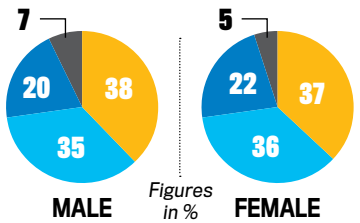
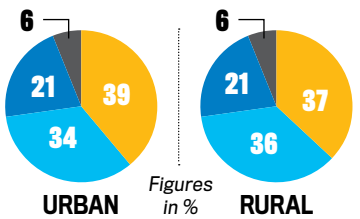
FRESH FROM NORTHEAST

FOR THE FIRST TIME, A NEW, THIRD PARTY, THE ZPM, HAS WON A CLEAR MANDATE IN MIZORAM. IT DID VERY WELL IN URBAN AREAS, WINNING ALL 12 SEATS IN AIZAWL CITY, FOUR IN LUNGLEI AND ALL THREE IN SERCHHIP. IN CONTRAST, THE MNF WON ALL OF ITS 10 SEATS IN RURAL AREAS. THE BJP, WITH TWO SEATS, IS NOW THE THIRD BIGGEST PARTY IN THE STATE

GENDER



GEOGRAPHY



Source: Axis My India and India Today bureau; Figures in percentage

Figures in () indicates share in total population

the constituency of outgoing chief minister Zoramthanga. Even so, ZPM still had to overcome the challenge of being seen as a party that attracted only the urban population. To reach out to rural voters, it promised administrative reforms to weed out alleged corruption in the MNF's New Economic Development Policy (NEDP), which was a rehash of the previous Congress regime's New Land Use Policy (NLUP). The ZPM's promise of minimum support price for four local crops—ginger, turmeric, chilli and broom grass—found several takers. However, what struck a chord with voters was the promise of a "new system" of clean, corruption-free governance aimed at economic progress and a drug-free society. With nearly 75 per cent of the population having access to the internet, the ZPM's narrative penetrated deep into villages in the hinterland.

To break free from legacy politicians, it fielded freshers, including local celebrities such as Jeje Lalpekhlua, a former member of the Indian national football team, Tetea Hmar, an executive member of the All India Football Federation, and Vanneihsangi, a radio jockey. In fact, 33 of the 40 candidates fielded by the ZPM were new entrants to politics. The party was also cautious not to allow the MNF to hijack the issue of Mizo nationalism. The MNF sought electoral dividends by taking up the cause of the Chin refugees from Myanmar who were persecuted by the military junta, and the Kukis from Manipur who fled the ethnic strife. Both communities have the same ethnicity as the Mizos. The ZPM made it clear that it shared the same policy as the MNF's for handling the refugee crisis. There was unanimity between the parties on other issues, such as border disputes with Assam, opposition to the Uniform Civil Code and the Citizenship Amendment Act, 2019. The MNF's disastrous performance in the poll—even Zoramthanga and deputy chief minister Tawnluia lost their seats—indicated that it was a vote for a change in governance.

This electoral outcome also marks the return of ZPM leader Lalduhoma to governmental office. Between 1972 and 1977, he served as a principal assistant to the then chief minister C. Chhunga. Later, he became an IPS officer and was part of the security detail of former prime minister Indira Gandhi, who inspired him to join politics. He won his first election in 1984 and entered the Lok Sabha as a Congress member. As Indira Gandhi's envoy, he played a critical role in brokering peace with Mizo rebel leader Laldenga, the MNF chief, which transitioned from an extremist group into a political party after the Mizo Peace Accord of 1986.

The same year, Lalduhoma fell out with the Congress and resigned from the party, which was seen as a violation of the anti-defection law of 1985. Two years later, he became the country's first MP to be disqualified under it. In 1997, he formed the Zoram Nationalist Party. He was elected to the state assembly in 2003. In 2018, he defeated incumbent chief minister Lalthanhawla of the Congress from Serchhip constituency. History repeated itself in 2020 when he was disqualified as an MLA under the defection law—he served as a ZPM leader, though he had been elected as an independent candidate.

WHAT STRUCK A CHORD WITH MOST VOTERS WAS THE ZPM'S PROMISE OF A "NEW SYSTEM" OF CLEAN, CORRUPTION-FREE GOVERNANCE AIMED AT ECONOMIC PROGRESS

As chief minister, the 74-year-old Lalduhoma's first priority will be to embark on economic reforms in Mizoram, which is under severe financial stress. The Covid-19 pandemic hit the economy hard and Mizoram's fiscal deficit widened to 7 per cent of the GSDP in FY23, breaching the target set in the Mizoram Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (Amendment) Act, 2020. Mizoram